

ACC vs. NOM objects with recipient passives in Faroese

Ditransitive passives are probably one of the most discussed areas of Faroese syntax and yet they remain rather poorly understood. In this paper, I will report on a recent survey of ditransitive passives in Faroese, thereby hoping to set the empirical record straight. I will also propose a formal analysis of the results of the ongoing change in ditransitive passives.

Thráinsson et al. (2012:269-271) maintain that the best passives of ditransitive verbs involve promotion of the theme argument to subject. Recipient passives, by contrast, are claimed to be marginal if the direct object is nominative and unacceptable with accusative direct objects, at least with a typical ditransitive verb like *geva* ‘give’ (see also Barnes 1986 and Galbraith 2018 for similar claims):

- (1a) Kúgvín varð seld bóndanum
cow-the.NOM.SG.F became sold.NOM.SG.F farmer-the.DAT
‘The cow was sold to the farmer.’
- (1b) ?Bóndanum varð seld ein kúgv
farmer-the.DAT became sold.NOM.SG.F a.NOM.SG.F cow-the.NOM.SG.F
‘The farmer was sold a cow.’
- (1c) *Bóndanum varð selt eina kúgv
farmer-the.DAT became sold.NOM.SG.N a.ACC.SG.F cow-the.ACC.SG.F

While it is quite clear that theme passives are the most common type of a ditransitive passives in Faroese, recipient passives are more acceptable than much previous work has indicated. Thus, in a survey of 62 native speakers, Eythórrsson (2012) found that recipient passives with an accusative or nominative direct object were judged acceptable by 17,7% and 25,8% of the participants, respectively. Moreover, my own field work indicates that the acceptance rate for recipient passives is much higher in some cases, especially if the theme object is accusative. For instance, (2a) below was accepted by 8 out of 16 informants whereas (2b) was accepted by 14 out of 16 informants.

- (2a) Løgtinginum vórðu givnar størri heimildir
parliament-the.DAT became.PL given.FEM.PL.NOM bigger allowances.FEM.PL.NOM
- (2b) Løgtinginum varð givið størri heimildir
parliament-the.DAT became.SG given bigger allowances.ACC
‘The parliament got permission for more spending.’

I will refer to the two competing grammars behind this variation as Grammar A (nominative theme) and Grammar B (accusative theme). Grammar A is the older grammar (as seen by comparison with Icelandic and Old Norse) that speakers strongly associate with formal language but Grammar B is the innovative grammar that is more common in informal registers.

The structure that I will be assuming for ditransitive clauses involves an ApplP, selected by *v*. The specifier of Appl is the dative indirect object and the complement is the theme:

- (3) [_{VP} SU [_V *v* [_{ApplP} IO [_{APPL}’ Appl DO]]]]

My proposal is that the variation between nominative and accusative themes in recipient passives boils down to the presence or absence of structural case assignment by Appl. If Appl does not assign accusative case to the theme (as in Grammar A), it will get nominative case from T since v cannot assign accusative in passives. By contrast, if Appl assigns accusative to the theme (as in Grammar B), nominative case assignment is blocked and no agreement is triggered with the finite verb or the passive participle. Note that this holds whether the dative recipient moves to Spec,T or not (see Eythórsson 2008, 2012 for relevant examples).

The choice between the two grammars makes no real difference in active clauses, where the theme will always be accusative, assigned by v in Grammar A but Appl in Grammar B. However, theme passives are a potential problem since only nominative is possible:

(4a) Størri heimildir vórðu givnar lögtinginum
 bigger allowances.NOM became.PL given.FEM.PL.NOM parliament-the.DAT

(4b) *Størri heimildir varð givið lögtinginum
 bigger allowances.ACC became.SG given parliament-the.DAT

This is not an issue in Grammar A where Appl does not assign accusative case. For Grammar B, we can assume that accusative themes cannot move to subject position in Faroese passives because they already have structural case. Note also that dative recipients can move to Spec,T because they do not have any structural case that conflicts with the nominative assigned by T. As is well-known, Faroese also allows dative subjects in active clause with experiencer verbs like *dáma* ‘like’.

The analysis advocated here is very close in spirit to that of Sigurðsson (2017), the main difference being that it does not rely on any post-syntactic mechanisms to determine how structural case is spelled out. According to Sigurðsson (2017), accusative themes with recipient passives are made possible by an algorithm that makes structural case be realized as accusative in the presence of a filled SpecApplP. By contrast, my analysis paints a simpler diachronic picture where the only change from Grammar A to Grammar B is that Appl acquires the ability to assign structural accusative case to the theme.

References

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